

Cortex-A12 is coming

ARM introduced Cortex-A12 chip offering better performance and battery than Cortex-A9, coming soon.
<http://dgit.in/10VGz9U>

Windows 8: A failure

Windows 8 is disliked by many users, justified by severe decrease in its growth rate
<http://dgit.in/12qOSAM>

HOW WE TESTED

Before we embarked on testing the GPS devices for this comparison test, we set a standard testing base for all the devices. Since these devices cannot be tested in a test centre environment and has to be done outdoors, we had to ensure that the conditions were the same for all devices.

Same routes for all

To ensure this, we charted out two test routes in Delhi NCR, which covered a heady mix of colony roads, main roads and National Highways, and some popular points of interest, like restaurants, cinema halls, et al. The idea was to see how the maps guide us on the popular main roads, and how precise they are on the colony roads while hunting for an address, which can often be confusing in Indian neighbourhoods.

Comparing the maps & navigation

Navigation devices of different brands have their own unique package, completely unrelated to the other. Their mapping is done in a different

way, and the maps themselves look very different. Navigation quality and even the ability to re-route a journey was tested to find out nuances between devices. Running all maps on the same route helped compare navigation quality and precision.

Same car, same driver, same driving style

To keep everything constant, we used the same car, with the same driver. Some of these devices have the Eco feature - calculate fuel average etc., and a standard driving style helps compare the accuracy. We did not want even a slight difference in engine displacement to have a bearing on the results.

What was tested?

Keeping all things constant, we tested and rated the devices on the following parameters.

Navigation quality: We rate the quality of navigation offered by each device, based on the precision on both the pre-set test routes.

Voice navigation: We rate all devices on the quality of voice navigation, the amount of options available for language and how audible the sound quality is, ease of listening, etc.

Display & sound quality: Two critical features on a navigation device. If you cannot see the map clearly and quickly while driving, or the audio isn't clear enough, then what is the point? These features are important.

Startup time: Just like most devices, it is important for a navigation device to start up quickly. More points awarded to the devices that take lesser time to start up and be ready for action.

GPS lock time: This is the final piece of the jigsaw. Once the GPS is locked on, after a complete boot, you can input your destination and be on your way. Again, the quicker devices score more points. We have also rated all the devices in terms of their build quality and any additional or unique features that they may offer.

Navi with Entertainment. The combination of black and silver around the bezel looks very classy. Most of the ports are on the left side spine - 3.5mm, microSD slot, and the Mini USB port. Flip the device over, and a black finish with a bit of self-imprint on it will greet you. The speaker is clearly visible on the bottom left - where the stylus is housed. However, it takes considerable effort to remove the stylus, since the chamber is too snug a fit. This navigator seems well-put together overall, and definitely looks a lot more expensive than it actually is.

The Primo GPS PG411G does have its good and bad points. It is very well built, and has a rather compact look to it, thanks to the thinner frame around the display. The build quality is quite solid, and so is the windshield mount. However, its glossy black finish means it'll be prone to scratches and will attract dust. All connectors



Garmin nuvi 40LM

and slots on the navigator's bevelled design are placed on the left spine, when you view it head on. The windshield mount also packs in a stylus, something that is unique to this GPS device. And the stylus is very useful to use on a resistive touchscreen.

MapMyIndia has given the Lx430 a distinct identity reminiscent of its higher-end

devices, complete with the soft feel finish. The bevelled design means the Lx340 looks thinner than it actually is. Good to look at and touch, but there are some rough edges. If you aren't careful while detaching the windshield mount, there is a visible gap that opens up where the front and back panels meet. Having said that, the device's port placement

and power key position are comfortable for operation.

The three TomTom devices, the VIA 100, VIA 120 and VIA 125 all look and feel exactly the same, apart from their different screen sizes. And still, this family of devices are the only ones that integrate the windshield mount on the back of the device itself, like a one-piece assembly. A very neat idea, and we still urge all GPS/PND device manufacturers to consider this, even though it is now 12 months since we last mentioned this! Even in terms of port and key placements, the three TomTom devices are by far the most unique looking ones off the bunch - power key on the back panel, no ports on the sides and the memory card slot in a tiny depression on the rear panel of the device. The build quality is quite good, too, except that it loses out on points for power key placement. Reaching behind the device is a tad uncomfortable.